ENGLISH WORDS
History, Meaning, and Structure

University of Glasgow

Neologisms: New and Improved

Marc Alexander

English Language & Linguistics 2A, Week 5

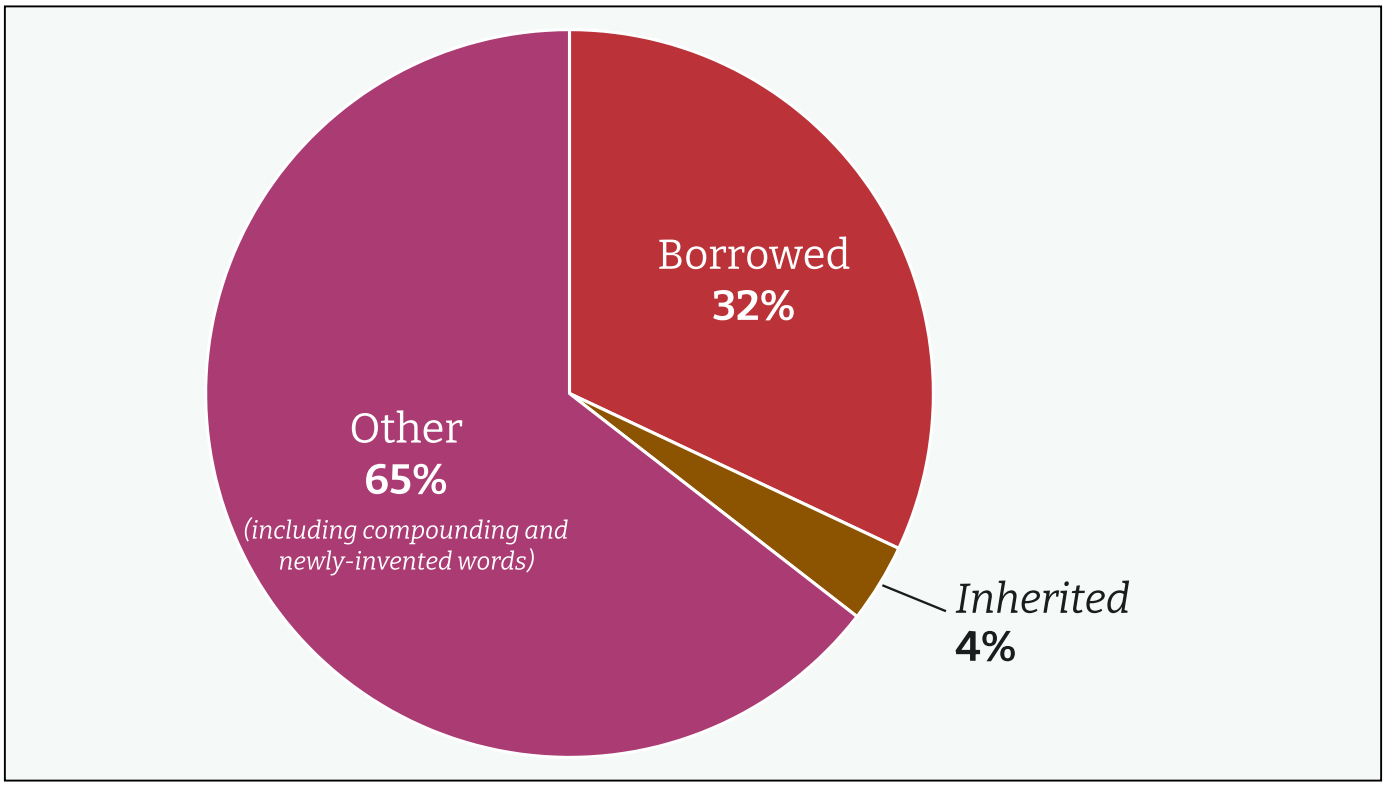
1

Inherited

Borrowed

Invented

2

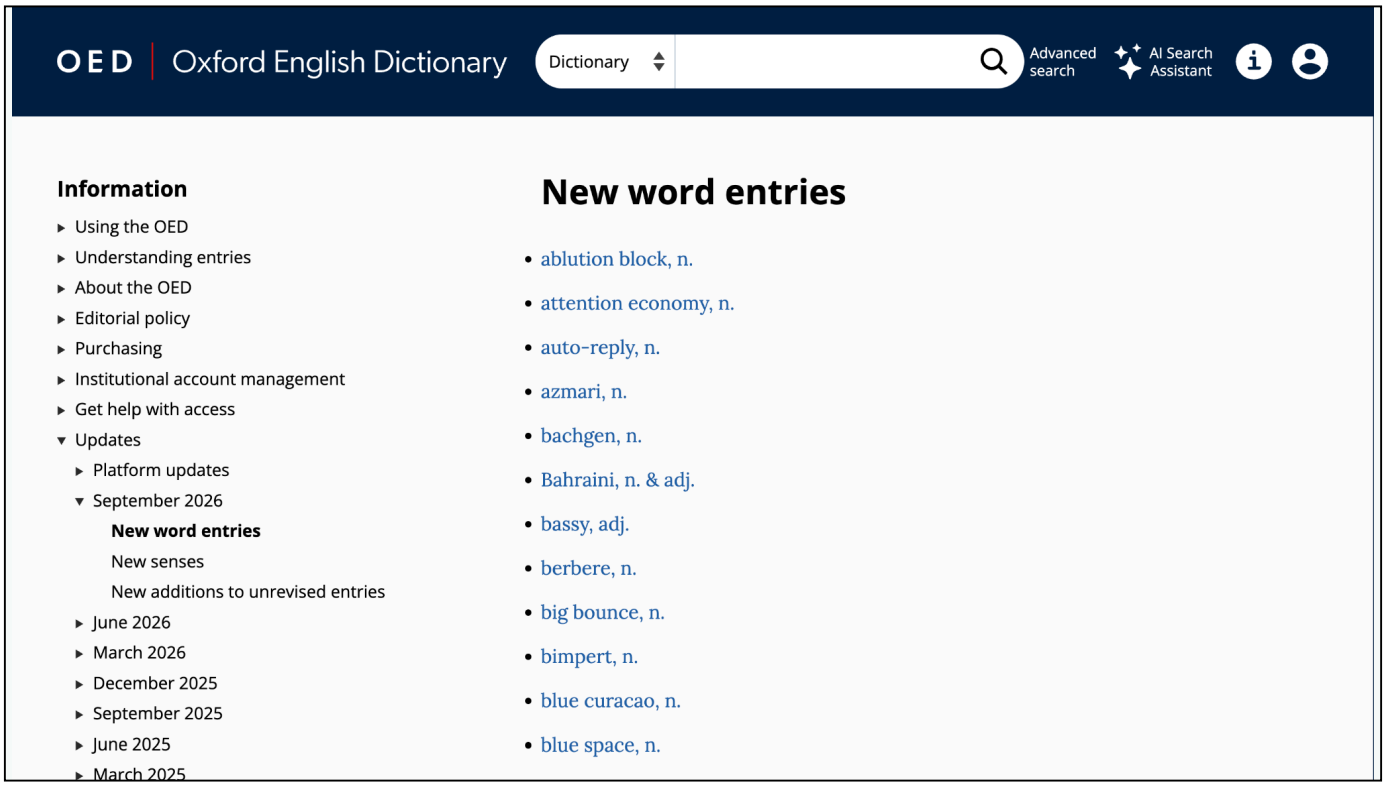


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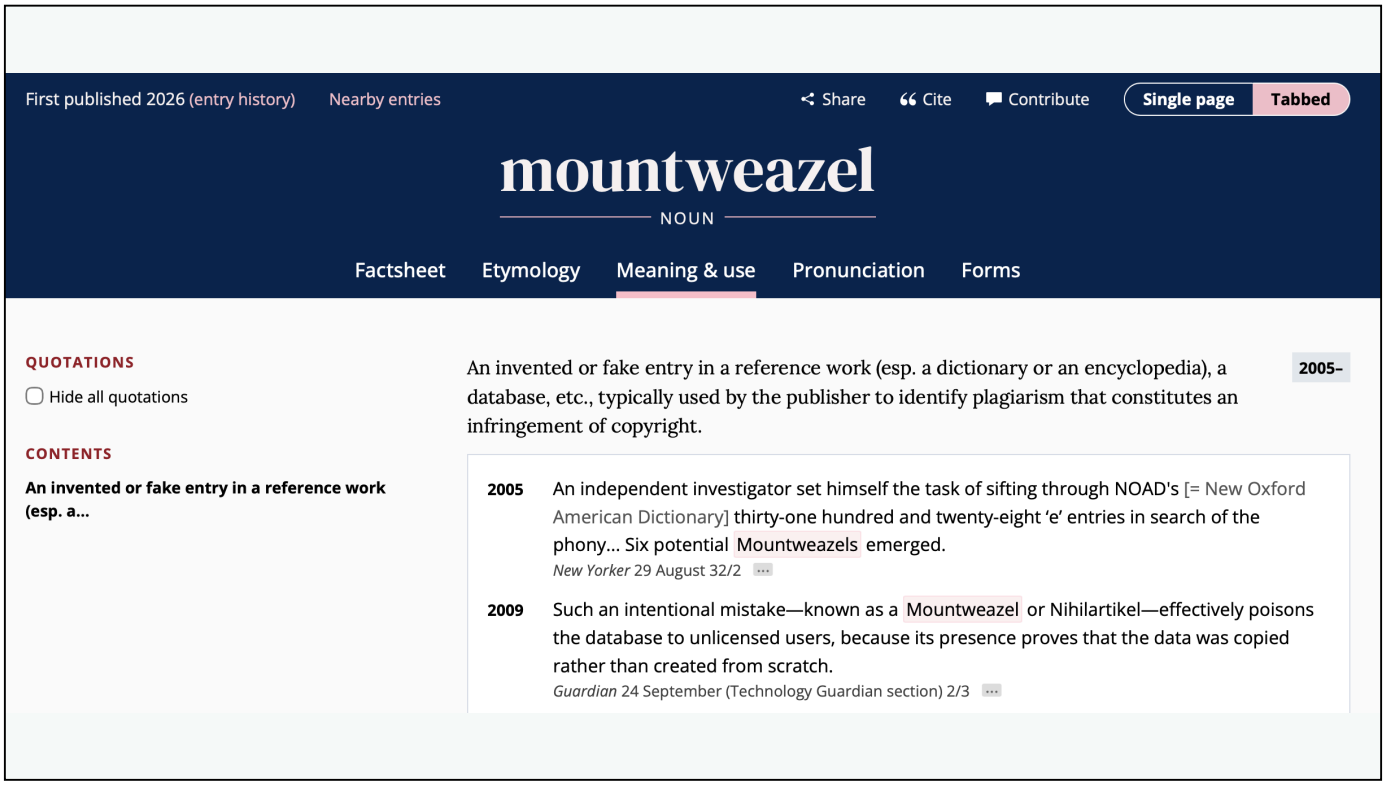
not a **real** word

a ‘made-up’ word

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OED | Oxford English Dictionary
Dictionary
Advanced search
AI Search Assistant
Information
Using the OED
Understanding entries
About the OED
Editorial policy
Purchasing
Institutional account management
Get help with access
Updates
Platform updates
September 2026
New word entries
New senses
New additions to unrevised entries
June 2026
March 2026
December 2025
September 2025
June 2025
March 2025
New word entries
ablution block, n.
attention economy, n.
auto-reply, n.
azmari, n.
bachgen, n.
Bahraini, n. & adj.
bassy, adj.
berbere, n.
big bounce, n.
bimpert, n.
blue curacao, n.
blue space, n.

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First published 2026 (entry history)
Nearby entries
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mountweazel
NOUN
Factsheet
Etymology
Meaning & use
Pronunciation
Forms
QUOTATIONS
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An invented or fake entry in a reference work (esp. a...
An invented or fake entry in a reference work (esp. a dictionary or an encyclopedia), a database, etc., typically used by the publisher to identify plagiarism that constitutes an infringement of copyright.
2005–
2005 An independent investigator set himself the task of sifting through NOAD's [= New Oxford American Dictionary] thirty-one hundred and twenty-eight 'e' entries in search of the phony... Six potential Mountweazels emerged.
New Yorker 29 August 32/2
2009 Such an intentional mistake—known as a Mountweazel or Nihilartikel—effectively poisons the database to unlicensed users, because its presence proves that the data was copied rather than created from scratch.
Guardian 24 September (Technology Guardian section) 2/3

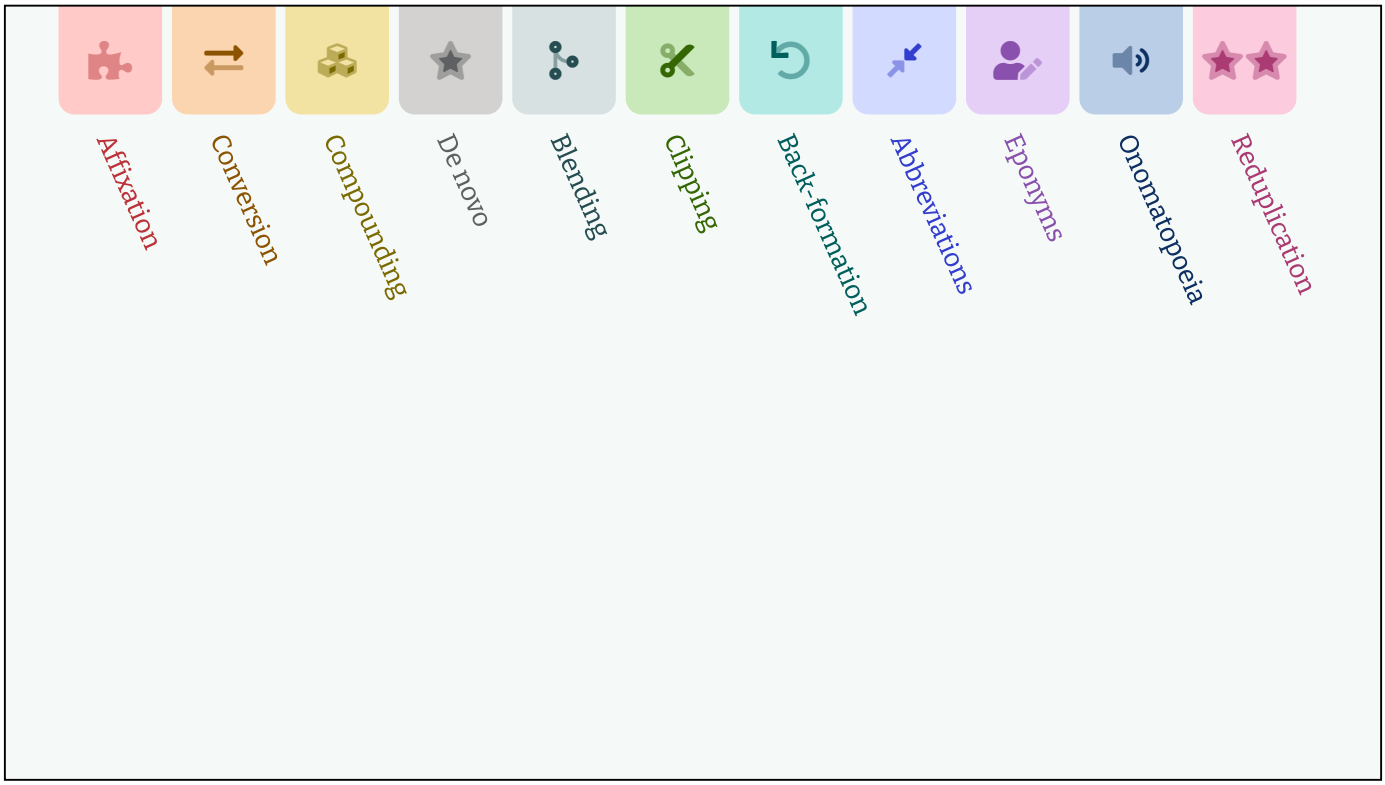
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ENGLISH WORDS

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Neologisms: How Do We Get New Words?

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Affixation

English affixes are used to create a **non-transparent** new word.

- *graceful/disgraceful*
- *spectacle/spectacles*
- *new/news*
- *hard/hardly*

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Conversion

Take a word form from another part of speech.

- *access*
- *email*
- *fish*
- *smooth*
- *gaatekeep*
- *convict*
- *present*
- *refuse*
- *torment*
- *record, rebel*

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Compounding

English **bases** are compounded together.

hovercraft	_____
bonfire	_____
holiday	_____
woman	_____
goodbye	_____
lord	_____
hussy	_____

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De novo

Entirely new word invented by putting together letters/sounds.

- *flabbergast*
- *gizmo*
- *Muppet*
- *Kodak*
- *Quark*
- *Jedi*
- *Viagra*
- *Prozac*
- *Nylon*

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Blending (*portmanteau*)

Taking parts of two words and merging them

brunch	_____
sitcom	_____
romantasy	_____
blog	_____
examnesia	_____
tradwife	_____

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Clipping

A shortened form of a word becomes a word in its own right.

flu	_____
hyper	_____
copter	_____
sci-fi	_____
gin	_____
rizz	_____

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Back-formation

Creation of words by (mistaken) analogy.

- *to burgle*
- *to buttle*
- *cherry*
- *grovel*

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Abbrev.

Taking the first letters, the first sounds, or the first few letters of words and combining them into a new word.

ACRONYMS

- *Nasa*
- *Shape*
- *Nato*
- *Laser*
- *Radar*
- *Modem*
- *Jeep*
- *Potus/Scotus*
- *Fubar/Snafu*
- *Lol (LOL?)*

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Abbrev.

Taking the first letters, the first sounds, or the first few letters of words and combining them into a new word.

INITIALISMS

- *FDR*
- *BBC*
- *UK*
- *AM/PM*
- *BC/AD*
- *CE/BCE*
- *MA/PhD*
- *LOL (Lol?)*
- *FAQ (Faq?)*
- *LLM*

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Eponyms

Words from names.

- *watt*
- *kelvin*
- *boycott*
- *cardigan*
- *lynch*
- *nicotine*
- *cheddar*
- *denim*
- *port*
- *sherry*
- *atlas*
- *morphine/morph*
- *panic*
- *to Instagram*

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Onomatopoeia

Emulating a sound in a word.

- *woof*
- *baa / bleat*
- *quack*
- *roar*
- *burble*
- *meow*
- *bang*
- *cuckoo*

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Reduplication

When part or all of a word is repeated.

- *hip-hop*
- *bonbon*
- *ping-pong*
- *itty-bitty*
- *mish-mash*
- *fifty-fifty*

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